GUIDEWIRE
DEVTrails
University Hackathon

Seed Scale Soar

The Economy - Your Survival Guide

Welcome to Guidewire DEVTrails 2026: Unicorn Chase a 6-week startup simulation where you don't just build software, you run a company.

Your team is a startup. You have DC (DEVTrails Coins) 1,00,000 in seed capital, a cloud bill that never stops growing, and investors who only fund winners. Your mission? Build an insurance-themed product, keep the lights on, and outsurvive everyone else.

You'll receive an official Problem Statement, a real-world insurance challenge that your startup must solve. You're not building in the dark. The problem gives you direction; your job is to solve it and then innovate on top. The teams that just meet the brief get funded. The teams that reimagine it become Unicorns.

And every Sunday at midnight, your weekly burn gets triggered. Every milestone, you pitch to investors for funding. Every phase, the bottom 25% of the leaderboard gets eliminated with no appeals, no second chances. And if your balance hits DC 0 at any point? You're bankrupt. Pack up. Game over.

The top 5 teams that survive all six weeks make it to DemoJam at DevSummit 2026 (IPO Day) — the grand finale where the best startups go public and the Unicorns are crowned.

This guide breaks down every way you earn money and every way you lose it. Read it. Memorize it. Your company's survival depends on it.

THE BURN: Where Your Money Disappears

Weekly Burn

Every Sunday at midnight, the system will automatically deduct the operational costs from your account. Ensure you have sufficient funds available to cover these overheads; No exceptions.

Phase	Weeks	Weekly Cost	Phase Total
Seed	1–2	DC 5,000	DC 15,000
Scale	3–4	DC 12,000	DC 24,000
Soar	5–6	DC 36,000	DC 36,000
TOTAL	**6 Weeks**	**—**	**DC 75,000**

You will burn DC 75,000 no matter what. That's the cost of playing.

Late Delivery Penalties

"If you missed your deadline, you're officially in the "fine" print, and trust me, the cost of stalling is anything but fine."

Pay your fees and submit your work now to stay in the game.

Delay	Seed	Scale	Soar
On Time	DC 0	DC 0	DC 0
1 Day Late	DC 12,000	DC 20,000	DC 40,000
2 Days Late	DC 15,000	DC 26,000	DC 52,000
3 Days Late	DC 18,000	DC 30,000	DC 60,000
3+ Days	ELIMINATED	ELIMINATED	ELIMINATED

Pro tip: Submit broken code on time. Fix it later. Being late is always more expensive than being imperfect.

Market Crash Fine

A regulatory shock has just hit the system with only 24 hours remaining. This is a mandatory compliance update that must be integrated before the deadline.

Event	Cost
Failed compliance check	DC 8,000 (flat)

You can't buy your way out. Unless!!! you already own a Sabotage Shield.

Expertise Marketplace

This is your unfair advantage. Real Guidewire engineers, insurance domain experts, and senior architects available on demand for 1-on-1 sessions. Think of it as an investment. An architecture review today could be the difference between a 3-star and a 5-star. The smartest teams don't just build in isolation; they get expert eyes on their work early and often.

Resource	Cost	What You Get
Office Hours	DC 4,000	30-min 1:1 with an engineer
Domain Session	DC 6,000	45-min deep-dive with an insurance expert
Architecture Review	DC 8,000	Senior engineer reviews your system design
Pitch Doctor	DC 10,000	Polish your demo & pitch before funding rounds

Team Moves

Startups evolve. Sometimes you find a rockstar developer mid-competition and need them on your roster. Sometimes two struggling teams realize they're stronger together. And sometimes let's be honest things aren't working out and it's better to split before you drag each other down.

You can acqui-hired/divest-fired new members, merge two teams into one, or de-merge a team into two. One rule applies to all moves: every team must have between 3 and 5 members at all times. No solo wolves, no army squads. And yes every move costs money.

Action	Cost	Rules
Acqui-hired/Divest-fired (add/remove a member)	DC 10,000	Max 5 members - Minimum 3 members per team
Merger (two teams to one)	40% of combined balance	Same university only @ Phase 2 only
De-Merger (one team to two)	DC 25,000	Same university only @ Phase 2 only

Power-Ups & Items

The boldest moves build the biggest empires. Spend smart or go home broke.

Item	Cost	Effect
Sabotage Shield	DC 3,000	Skip one Market Crash fine
Intel Report / Wildcard API	DC 12,000	Unlock a premium third-party API
The Insider	DC 15,000	See next phase's problem statement 24h early
Double Down	Up to DC 8,000	Stake up to DC 8,000 on your performance. If you achieve a 3-star rating or higher, we'll double your investment. If you fall short, you lose the entire stake.

THE EARNS: How You Stay Alive

Funding Rounds (The Big Money)

At the end of each phase, you submit your product code, demo, and all. Then comes the moment of truth: a panel of investors tears through your architecture, UX, and logic to see if you actually built something worth backing.

They will hand you a Star Rating that dictates the size of your funding cheque. Low stars? You are scraping by. Five stars? You just secured the bag. The difference between a pass and a powerhouse is not just a bonus; it is the difference between surviving the week and dominating the market.Funding is your lifeline. A consistent 3-star team earns DC 82,000 — just enough to cover the DC 75,000 burn. Anything less and you're bleeding cash.

Quality	Seed (W2)	Scale (W3-4)	Soar (W5-6)	Total
5-Star	DC 40,000	DC 55,000	DC 65,000	DC 1,60,000
4-Star	DC 32,000	DC 42,000	DC 50,000	DC 1,24,000
3-Star	DC 22,000	DC 28,000	DC 32,000	DC 82,000
2-Star	DC 12,000	DC 15,000	DC 18,000	DC 45,000
1-Star	DC 5,000	DC 6,000	DC 8,000	DC 19,000
No Submission	DC 0	DC 0	DC 0	DC 0

CTF Challenges (2 Events Total)

Hack. Solve. Get paid. Two CTF days across the competition.

Flag	Per Flag	Available	Max Earn
Easy	DC 1,500	3	DC 4,500
Medium	DC 3,500	2	DC 7,000
Hard	DC 6,000	2	DC 12,000
Boss	DC 10,000	1	DC 10,000
Max Per Day	**—**	**—**	**DC 33,500**
Max Total (2 days)	**—**	**—**	**DC 67,000**

Weekly Quizzes

Insurance + Cloud knowledge checks. Fast money for smart teams.

Item	Amount
Correct Answer (x20)	DC 400 each, DC 8,000 max
1st Place Bonus	DC 5,000
2nd Place Bonus	DC 3,000
3rd Place Bonus	DC 1,500

Community & Engagement

Cap: DC 15,000 per week. You can't meme your way to victory but it helps. Teams can generate supplementary cash flow by actively participating in the ecosystem. Unlike technical deliverables, these rewards focus on collaboration, marketing, and feedback.

Activity	Earning	Limit
Social Media Post (tag us!)	DC 2,000	Max 2 per phase
Q&A Power Question (in webinars)	DC 800	Moderator's call
Dev Blog / Vlog	DC 2,500	Max 1 per phase
Peer Help (in #help channel)	DC 2,500	Must be confirmed
Fail Night Winner	DC 8,000	Peer-voted best failure story

Bounties (Surprise Drops)

Flash challenges. First to finish wins.

Event	Reward
First N teams to complete	DC 8,000

Achievements (One-Time Bonuses)

Unlock these and get a permanent cash injection.

Achievement	Requirement	Bonus
Streak Master	3 consecutive 4-star+ ratings	DC 10,000
Zero Debt (Phase 3)	Never pay a single late penalty	DC 8,000
Philanthropist	Help 5+ teams publicly	DC 6,000
Perfectionist	All 5-star ratings	DC 20,000
Scholar	Win 3 quiz podiums	DC 7,000

YOUR RANK — Where Do You Stand?

Not every startup becomes a Unicorn. The leaderboard follows a bell curve just like the real market. Your rank is based on your star ratings, financial health, and overall performance across phases. Here's where teams land:

Tier	Who Makes It	Out of 100 Teams
Diamond	Top 15%; The Unicorns. Flush with cash, consistent 4–5-star ratings. Everyone wants to be you.	15 Teams
Gold	Next 25%; Strong and stable. One big win away from Diamond.	25 Teams
Silver	Middle 35%; Surviving, but barely. One bad week and you're sliding into Bronze.	35 Teams
Bronze	Bottom 25%; The danger zone. The math is not in your favor.	25 Teams
Eliminated	Bankrupt or cut at end-of-phase. Gone.	—

Every phase, the bottom 25% gets eliminated. The leaderboard isn't just for bragging rights, it decides who lives and who dies. Stay out of Bronze.

Build fast. Spend smart. Don't go broke. Happy Hacking.